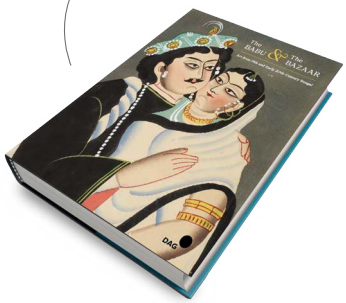
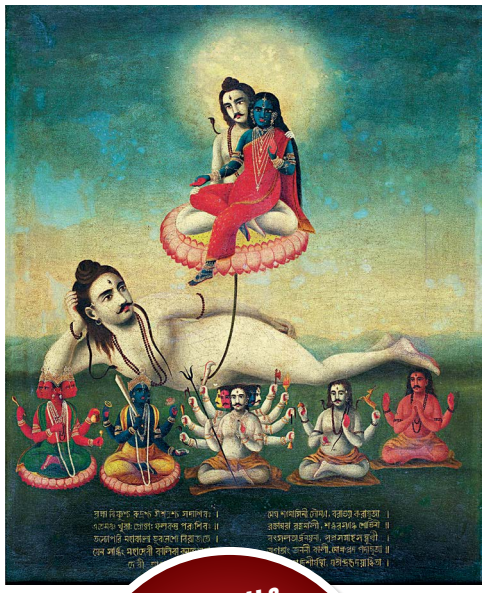
THE BABU & THE BAZAAR
Art from 19th and Early 20th Century Bengal
Aditi Nath Sarkar with Shatadeep Maitra
DAG
₹6,000; 318 pages

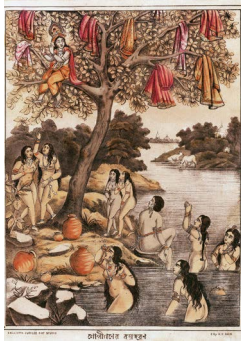






Courtesy: DAG







A SHARED CONTEXT
Selected artworks from the exhibition and its accompanying volume

THE BABU & THE BAZAAR Art From 19th And Early 20th Century Bengal is showing at DAG, 22A, Janpath Road, Windsor Place, New Delhi, till July 1 (11 am – 7 pm)

EXHIBITION

ENTANGLED *Imaginings*

The Babu and the Bazaar is a reminder of the scandalous fecundity and delight on offer in the visual arts of colonial Calcutta

An oil painting depicting Draupadi's *vastraharan* with a distinctly European gaze, 'reverse-glass' paintings of the Hindu pantheon churned out by ateliers in Canton, a pin-up print of a voluptuous merry widow. And an unconscious rendering of the Indian subcontinent's sacred geography as Saraswati. These are just some of the wildly diverse and yet kindred images on display at the DAG gallery's new flagship showroom in Delhi—and in the sumptuous volume that commemorates it.

As the show's title suggests, these eclectic pictures are united by time (19th and early 20th century) and place (Bengali). This shared context is productively and provocatively explored in the text, which draws out a visual genealogy that goes back to the scroll paintings used by *patua* performing artists. The transformation of that kinetic folk-art form into more static individual frames for solipsistic consumption is a well-documented parable of Indian art's encounter with colonial modernity and the age of mechanical reproduction. But by juxtaposing watercolour *pats* with a range of art in other mediums—oil paintings, woodcuts, metal engravings, lithographs and chromolithographs—that were jostling for attention in the art bazaar that was colonial Calcutta, this selection offers a reminder of the scandalous fecundity and visual delight of this encounter.

While the march of money and class is explicit in the ostentation of the oil paintings or the precious metals slathered on some prints, it becomes clear that social hierarchy was constantly subverted in this melting pot of aesthetics, technology and